top brass sent out a clear message, saying there would be no rollback and that eligible applicants who were found to have participated in the agitation would be disqualified. Prime Minister Narendra Modi reiterated the government's stand when, at a public rally in Bengaluru, he said, "Many reforms, in the present, may seem unpleasant. But over time, the entire country experiences their benefits. Only the path of reforms can take us to new milestones." Like many other decisions of the Modi government, it is a bold and brave idea whose time has come. But the devil lies not just in the details, but also in its execution. The proposition is risky for many reasons. Here are some.

IS THE AGNIPATH SCHEME THE BEST WAY FORWARD?

Agnipath is meant solely for the recruitment of soldiers, sailors and airmen, not officers. Under the scheme, 46,000 recruits called Agniveers (40,000 for the army and 3,000 each for the navy and air force) between the ages of 17 and a half and 21 will be inducted this year. (The upper age limit has since been increased to 23 years to compensate for those who missed out because recruitment was suspended for two years due to Covid). They will serve for four years including a training period of 6-8 months, at the end of which only 25 per cent of them would be selected for induction into the regular military cadre to serve for a further 15 years. The remaining 75 per cent would be discharged with a termination package of Rs 10.04 lakh, along with accrued interest, which would be exempt from income tax. The ex-Agniveers, however, will not be entitled to pension, gratuity, health, canteen stores department facilities, ex-serviceman status and related benefits. This is unlike the earlier recruitment policy where those selected go on to serve for a minimum of 15 years unless their services are terminated for indiscipline or medical reasons. The armed forces believe that the training imparted to Agniveers in these four years will make them eligible for employment not only in other government departments but also in the private sector.

The aim is to reduce the age profile of the armed forces, which is currently pegged at a high average of 32 years and bring it down to 26 years. This would be in keeping with the worldwide trend—the average age of a soldier in the UK is 25 years and that in the US, 27. In fact, major powers, including China, US and Russia, have both such short-term voluntary and conscript schemes for their armed forces (see India vs. the World). The need to lower the age profile of the Indian armed forces was felt as far back as after the 1999 Kargil conflict. The Kargil Review Committee had flagged the need to reduce the age of soldiers and make units younger. Air Chief Marshal V.R. Chaudhari, chief of air staff, says, "We are well aware of the new domains of warfare and for that, we need a new breed of young warriors. The force optimisation—both quantitative and qualitative—is also taking place at the same time."

> The army needs to right-size as the sepoy to NCO or ***josh-to-hosh* ratio is a worrying 1:1.28**, pushing up the age profile of the force

The need is even more acute for the army. The sepoy to NCO (non-commissioned officer) ratio is a worrying 1:1.28. This means there are more NCOs per jawan, pushing up the age profile of the army. Lt Gen. Anil Puri, an additional secretary in the department of military affairs (DMA), calls it the *josh-to-hosh* ratio. Pegging the ideal ratio at 1:1, he says, "You then get the ideal mix of youth and experience, which is the hallmark of a formidable fighting force." DMA hopes to achieve this ratio by 2030 with Agnipath, with a steady induction of young blood and the continuous retirement of the older jawans.

WILL IT HELP RIGHT-SIZE THE ARMED FORCES?

While Agnipath has been hailed as a step in the right direction, there is no mention officially of the real reason behind the radical reform—paring the salary and pension bill of the armed forces. The money thus saved can be channeled into much-needed capital procurement for the defence forces. The imbalance is obvious--of the total defence allocation of Rs 5.25 lakh crore in 2022-23, the capital expenditure for new equipment and infrastructure development is only Rs 1.44 lakh crore, or 27.4 per cent of the total.

That is because year after year, a huge chunk of the defence budget—as much as 53 per cent—goes toward paying salaries and pensions. The Rs 1.19 lakh crore allocated to pensions of defence personnel is, in fact, more than the revenue expenditure of critical ministries like health. A 2022-23 report by PRS Legislative Research points out how the budget for pensions grew at an annual rate of 10.7 per cent in the past decade, which is higher than the average annual growth rate of the defence budget at 8.6 per cent. The Modi government's decision to adopt the One Rank One Pension scheme in July 2014 also pushed up expenses further. As a result, the allocation for capex meant to procure big-ticket weapons, fighter jets, submarines, helicopters and other modern military systems has shrunk at a time when our armed forces face a two-front threat from China and Pakistan.

Agnipath will partly help right-size the armed forces, particularly the army, which has bloated over the decades. Currently, as much as 76 per cent of its annual budget of Rs 3.06 lakh crore goes toward honouring its salaries and pensions commitments, and only 8 per cent